

Where to Get Help in Boulder Creek

Free food, a library card that does far more than books, weekly programs for kids, and the numbers to call when you don't know who to call. Most of this is run by neighbors and easy to miss if nobody points you at it.

IF YOU ONLY REMEMBER ONE THING, REMEMBER 211

Dial **211**, or text your ZIP code to **211211**. It covers more than 500 local resources for food, housing, benefits, childcare subsidies, and counseling referrals. Phone and text run 24 hours a day, seven days a week, with interpretation in 150 languages. It is a program of United Way of Santa Cruz County.

FOOD

Free Food Fridays. Every Friday from 3 p.m. until the food is gone, rain or shine, in the open lot next to Jenna Sue's Cafe downtown. Leftover produce and groceries from the Grey Bears Healthy Food program, handed out by volunteers through the Boulder Creek Recreation and Park District. No questions asked, no paperwork. On wet days it moves to Junction Park.

Valley Churches United Missions, 9400 Highway 9, Ben Lomond (831) 336-8258

An every-other-week grocery pickup for enrolled San Lorenzo Valley households, plus clothing and seasonal programs. Worth a call if you need more than food.

Second Harvest Food Bank, county-wide distributions (831) 662-0991

Find the nearest distribution at thefoodbank.org.

Grey Bears, free weekly grocery bag for county residents 55+ (831) 479-1055

Meals on Wheels, weekday lunches for adults 60+ (831) 464-3180

Hot lunches at the Highlands Park Senior Center on Highway 9 in Ben Lomond, plus delivery for homebound seniors.

THE LIBRARY CARD IS THE BEST FREE THING IN TOWN

Boulder Creek Branch Library, 13390 West Park Avenue (831) 427-7703

Monday to Thursday 10 a.m. to 6 p.m., Friday 11 a.m. to 5 p.m., Saturday 10 a.m. to 5 p.m.

A card is free and covers far more than books: wifi, public computers, and wireless printing; **Discover & Go** passes to museums and parks around the region; the **Library of Things**, which lends objects and equipment rather than media; and the **Felton Seed Library**, free garden seeds you can take and grow.

Free programs for kids run weekly: **storytime** on Wednesdays and the **Discovery Zone playgroup**, a free-play hour for children up to five with an adult, Friday mornings at 11. **R.E.A.D.** offers free one-on-one reading help for grades 1 through 12 by appointment, (831) 427-7713. A mobile health clinic visits the branch monthly, and summer brings extra performances and reading-program events.

ONE THING THAT HAS ENDED

The **BCRPD Community Tool Shed** lent tools for free for years after the CZU fire, from shovels and rakes to log splitters. The district announced weekly rentals closing in August 2026 and that program has wound down, so it is no longer a way to borrow a tool. We are leaving it on this sheet because people still ask. If something takes its place, the district will know: (831) 338-4144.

FAMILIES AND CHILDCARE

Child Development Resource Center, county referrals to licensed care (831) 466-5820

Toll-free (833) 774-4596, weekdays 8 to 5. Free referrals to licensed centers and family child care homes anywhere in the county, plus help with subsidies.

Boulder Creek Recreation and Park District

(831) 338-4144

Camps, youth programs, a seasonal pool, and adult classes. Downtown office at 13333 Middleton Avenue, Tuesday to Friday 10 a.m. to 2 p.m.

NEIGHBOR-TO-NEIGHBOR

Community potluck. The BCRPD Foundation hosts a free, everyone-welcome meal on the second Sunday of the month, 4 to 7 p.m. Bring a dish if you can, and canned goods for the food drive.

Buy Nothing Boulder Creek. A local Facebook group where neighbors give away and ask for things, from furniture to garden starts.

Little Free Libraries. Take-a-book, leave-a-book boxes all over town. Once you start noticing them you see them everywhere.

Giving instead of needing? Free Food Fridays and Valley Churches United both take donations, and Grey Bears will collect extra food or glean fruit from your trees.

In an emergency, call 911. For non-emergency help finding a service, 211 is faster than searching, and the people answering know what is actually open this week.

Numbers, hours, and program details verified against each organization's own information. Small volunteer-run programs change their schedules and sometimes end, as the Tool Shed's rentals did, so call ahead before making a trip. Checked July 2026. Something changed, or a resource missing? Tell us at bouldercreeklocal.com.